

I understood Advocacy as speaking up for people when they have nobody to defend them. As I continued my student counseling journey, I quickly understood that advocacy is way more than that. Counselors are able to advocate for clients in different ways such as providing resources, educating others, helping them overcome barriers, and being the voice to marginalized communities that continue to experience unequal access to resources, discrimination, and lack of opportunities due to their religion, background, or disability. Advocacy also starts by getting to know the clients individual background, experiences, and culture to be better equipped when seeking the resources that they need to thrive outside of counseling sessions. This has helped me see how important it is to be aware of the challenges that different populations face when trying to access mental health services.

One way I have practiced being an advocate has been through my involvement being a communications officer with Comunidad de Consejeros Bilingües (CCB) at UT San Antonio. Designing flyers for different workshops and distributing through social media has been rewarding when I participate in workshops and people show up because they saw the flyer. A workshop that impacted me as a future counselor was attending the Immigration: Protecting Your Clients workshop because I was able to understand immigration-related concerns and how it affects clients and their family. Another workshop helped me understand the importance of using inclusive language within diverse populations. Being able to recognize the importance in respecting a client's language, identity, and culture goes a long way in the therapeutic alliance formed in session. Overall, I have grown in my understanding of advocacy since I first began my coursework. I no longer see advocacy as something separate from counseling, but as an important part of being an effective counselor.